power." American embassy officials perceived greater anticommunism and Soviet-skepticism among the JP's individual leaders. Desai and JP-constituent Bharatiya Jana Sangh's Atal Behari Vajpayee and Lal Krishna (L. K.) Advani had indeed criticized Indian overdependence on Moscow, and the Bharatiya Lok Dal's Charan Singh had regretted the impact of the Indo-Soviet treaty on US-India relations.[92]

Brzezinski reported to Carter that the JP's victory was a "major shift" in Indian politics, but not in foreign policy. The new government might be "less well disposed" to Moscow, but "no rational Indian Government can reject the Soviet Union as long it feels threatened by China." It was good that Desai was not a US-skeptic, but a "pro-American tilt" could be a challenge if it came with high expectations of economic and political help that Washington could not deliver. With disparate voices and ideologies in the JP—some "chauvinistic"—the national security adviser recommended waiting and watching.[93] Thus, when Vice President Walter Mondale suggested a high-level visit to India, the NSC recommended against it at that point.[94]

For the US, nonetheless, the new Indian government offered an opportunity. Brzezinski was pessimistic about India's long-term future, but felt a significant improvement in relations was "highly desirable" at that stage.[95] A few factors facilitated a reset. First was what Deputy Secretary of State Warren Christopher would call "the magnificent resurrection of democracy," which Carter would cite in a major foreign policy speech that summer.[96] Second was Desai's known opposition to nuclear weapons (though this was a subject of difference within the JP).[97] Third was JP's emphasis on "proper nonalignment." The administration noticed Desai's initial remarks that he would not let the Indo-Soviet treaty be a veto on relations with others. He also made it a point to criticize not just American but also Soviet naval activities in the Indian Ocean.[98] So Carter reached out to Desai, writing the first letter of what would become a regular exchange between the two leaders.[99]

Desai's first foreign policy remarks to parliament as prime minister were more cautious. He reiterated the importance of "genuine nonalignment," but said his government would keep its commitments. The US interpretation was that the Indian government would not repudiate the Soviet treaty, but it would seek a "better balance." Foreign Secretary Jagat Mehta, after